

ASHLEY HOI-TING AU

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SKILLS

Programming: Python (NumPy, Pandas, PyTorch, TensorFlow), Java, MATLAB, SQL

Mathematics: Probability, Statistical Inference, Optimization, Time-Series Analysis

Tools: Git, Linux, Docker, LaTeX

Specialized: AI Safety, Distributed Learning, Graph Neural Networks

RESEARCH & EXPERIENCE

Benchmarking Unauthorized Distillation Should Be Attack–Defense Co-Evaluation Under API Constraints *Preprint.*

- (CaMLSys collaboration) Position paper arguing unauthorized distillation of proprietary foundation model APIs are currently benchmarked incorrectly.

What Was Forgotten? Black-Box Discovery of Hidden Forget Targets in Unlearned LLMs *Preprint.*

- (CaMLSys collaboration) Uncovering forgotten data extraction from *Q&A LLM*.

DG-CoLearn: An Efficient Collaborative Learning Framework for Dynamic Graphs *Preprint.*

- Proposed a lightweight collaborative learning framework without retraining the entire graph snapshot
- Designed a duo-stage graph partitioning algorithm in C++ for optimized computation distribution.
- *Results:* Achieved 33.8× speedup in training time with competitive performance.

Transforming Threats to Assets: Utilizing Malicious Backdoor Attack Models in FL *Accepted TCE 2025.*

- Developed an aggregation method leveraging malicious models for improved FL training.
- Designed custom feature engineering & clustering to detect malicious clients from anomaly patterns.
- *Results:* 35% improvement in reducing backdoor accuracy.

Cathay Pacific Airways *Lantau Island, Hong Kong*

IT & Digital Internship *Jul 2022 - Aug 2022*

- Built a robust threat-hunting model for the Security Operations team, integrating with the Mandiant Portal.
- Integrated Cathay Shop with Web 3.0 for innovative customer engagement.
- **Award:** Grand Award, 2022 Summer Internship Innovation Project.

EDUCATION

Visiting Researcher, CaMLSys, University of Cambridge *Oct 2025 - Present*

Supervisor: Prof Nicholas D. Lane

Conducted collaborative research on security and unlearning strategies on Large Language Models.

PhD, Computer Science, University of Warwick *Oct 2023 - Present*

Supervisor: Dr Ligang He

A driven academic researcher interested in solving potential problems in Federated Learning and Secure AI.

Master of Engineering, Discrete Mathematics, University of Warwick *Sep 2019 - Jul 2023*

Completed a joint degree of Computer Science and Mathematics, gaining rigorous understanding of the subjects' theoretical aspects as well as applications to practical problems.

OTHER EXPERIENCES

Open Source Contribution, Flower Framework *June 2025*

- Contributed to [Flower 1.19](#) by extending FedProx baseline to support FEMIST dataset with preprocessing matching the original paper
- **Pull Request impact:** Merged, 14 commits, 33 files changed.